By Amarnath K. Menon

ANDHRA PRADESH/ JAGAN REDDY

LEANING OVER BACKWARDS

It's been seven decades since the first elections were held in India, but caste arithmetic still remains integral to this democratic exercise. So, when Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy addressed the ruling YSR Congress's 'Jayaho BC Mahasabha' in Vijayawada on December 7, it was the same backward classes math that was decidedly on his mind.

In February 2019, just ahead of the last assembly election, Jagan—vying to dethrone then CM and Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief N. Chandrababu Naidu—had tried to woo the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in the state with a slew of promises in his party's BC Declaration unveiled at Eluru. Now, with the next state poll due in 2024—coinciding with the general election—Jagan shared his government's 'report card' at the well-attended outreach programme in Vijayawada, spelling out the promises fulfilled so far and reaffirming his commitment to social justice.

About 145 socially and economically backward classes (notified as OBCs collectively) account for 45-50 per cent of the state's population, and have traditionally backed the TDP ever since its founder, the late N.T. Rama Rao, stormed the undivided Andhra Pradesh in 1983. Their support was a key factor that helped the TDP garner nearly 40 per cent vote share in the 2019 election, even as it could net just 23, or 13 per cent, of the 175 assembly seats. The Jagan-led YSRC won 151 seats with a 50 per cent vote share.

"BCs are not backward classes but the backbone of society," emphasised the YSRC supremo at Vijayawada, pointing out that the government had disbursed Rs 1,63,000 crore, including Rs 86,000 crore under Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), to BC communities in the past three-and-a-half years. "We have taken steps to empower every disadvantaged section," he added. In doing so, Jagan has relied on the same strategy his father Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy had adopted as the Congress CM of undivided Andhra Pradesh—that is, ensuring the economic empowerment of all sections of society. So, if the YSRC chief has launched specific schemes targeting BC groups according to their occupation, such as Matsyakara Bharosa for fishermen, there are also schemes like Cheyutha, Amma Vodi and Jagananna Vasathi Deevena



MOHAMMAD ALEEMUDDIN

RAISING THE BAR Jagan at his party's Jayaho BC Mahasabha in Vijayawada, Dec. 7

TAKING A CUE FROM YSR'S STRATEGY OF SOCIAL JUSTICE, JAGAN IS BANKING ON OBC OUTREACH TO OVERCOME ANTI-INCUMBENCY